AVSPMC

Free guide for private owners

Home-builder checklist

What to check at each stage of building a villa or independent house in India, from buying the plot to moving in. Tick each item as you go.

1. Before you design

- [ ] Title deed, encumbrance certificate and mutation records checked by a lawyer
  Confirm the seller's ownership and that there are no loans or disputes on the land.
- [ ] Land use and building rules confirmed with the local authority
  Zoning, permitted floor area (FSI/FAR), setbacks, height limit and parking rules for your plot.
- [ ] Soil investigation report from a qualified geotechnical firm
  The structural engineer needs it to design the foundations.
- [ ] A total budget written down, including a contingency of 10% or more
  Include design fees, approvals, utilities, interiors and furniture, not just construction.
- [ ] A rough timeline agreed in your family, with the date you need to move in

2. Design

- [ ] Written brief for the architect: rooms, sizes, how you live, budget and must-haves
- [ ] Architect and structural engineer appointed with written scopes and fees
- [ ] MEP (plumbing, electrical, air-conditioning) designed, not left to the contractor
- [ ] Full drawing set before tender: plans, sections, elevations, structural, MEP, door and window schedule
- [ ] Specifications written down: brands and grades of cement, steel, tiles, fittings, wiring
- [ ] Design reviewed against the budget before drawings are frozen
  Changing a drawing on paper is cheap; changing it on site is not.

3. Approvals

- [ ] Building plan sanction received before any work starts on site
- [ ] Other approvals your project needs identified early (for example tree cutting, fire NOC for taller buildings, environmental clearance for large sites)
- [ ] Temporary electricity and water connections arranged for construction
- [ ] Copies of every approval kept in one file, with validity dates noted

4. Choosing the contractor

- [ ] At least three contractors invited, all pricing the same drawings and bill of quantities
- [ ] Past projects visited and previous clients called
- [ ] Bids compared line by line, including what each one leaves out
- [ ] Written contract signed: scope, price, programme, payment stages, penalties for delay, retention and defects period
  Retention of around 5% of each bill, released after the defects period, is common practice.
- [ ] Payments linked to completed work, not to dates
- [ ] Contractor's all-risk insurance and labour registrations confirmed

5. During construction: inspect before it gets covered

- [ ] Setting out checked against the drawings before excavation
- [ ] Foundation depth and soil checked by the structural engineer before concreting
- [ ] Reinforcement checked (bar sizes, spacing, cover, laps) before every concrete pour
- [ ] Concrete cube samples taken and tested at 7 and 28 days
- [ ] Shuttering and props checked before slab pours; props left for the specified time
- [ ] Electrical conduits and plumbing lines checked and pressure-tested before plastering
- [ ] Waterproofing of terraces, bathrooms and tanks tested by ponding before tiling
- [ ] Materials delivered match the agreed brands and grades; delivery notes kept
- [ ] Weekly site photos and a short progress note kept, with every change agreed in writing
- [ ] Bills checked against measured work before you pay

6. Finishing and handover

- [ ] Snag list walked room by room; every item fixed and re-checked
- [ ] All services tested: water pressure, drainage, every switch and socket, AC, pumps
- [ ] As-built drawings, manuals and warranties handed over in one file
- [ ] Occupancy or completion certificate obtained
- [ ] Final account agreed and retention release date written down

> **Signs you need help:** bills arriving faster than work, drawings changed on site without paper, the contractor asking for advances to keep going, or no one able to tell you the finish date.

AVSPMC manages building projects on the owner's side across India. avspmc.avsllp.co
General guidance only. Rules and approvals vary by state and city; check with your architect, engineer and local authority.